any sense of nationhood till the nineteenth century. However, as we have seen, Indians have had a very strong sense of being a civilization for millennia. Why did the Indians not oppose British rule more aggressively?

In my view, the real reason for this was that the collapse of the Mughal Empire in the eighteenth century had left the country in chaos. The Marathas, after showing some initial promise, had dissolved into their internal bickerings. The countryside was plagued with mercenaries and bandits of every description. Some of these privateer warlords, like Begum Samroo, became so powerful and rich that they lived openly and in style in Delhi and were considered respectable members of society. The East India Company was far from benign but, in comparison, did offer some semblance of order. There is an important additional factor. Unlike the Portuguese, the early British rulers conspicuously kept away from interfering with local culture and social norms. Even in the few instances where they did intervene, as in the abolition of the despicable custom of sati, it was done with the strong support of reformist Indians. This is why they would not have appeared as a civilizational threat to the contemporary Indian. It is not usually remembered that after his great victory at Plassey, Robert Clive did not offer thanksgiving at a church but at a Durga Puja organized by Nabakrishna Deb in Kolkata. One cannot picture Pedro Alvarez Cabral doing this.

Unfortunately, by the mid-nineteenth century, this open attitude had changed and we see growing cultural and racial arrogance. There is a distinct emphasis on ‘civilizing’, often meaning Christianizing, the natives. This was no secret but openly discussed. James Mill, author of *The History of British India* (1820), described Hinduism as ‘the most enormous and tormenting superstition that ever harassed and degraded any portion of mankind’. [7] Evangelical missionaries began using British political control to aggressively seek converts. Not surprisingly, Indians—both Hindu and Muslim—looked on all this with suspicion.

The resultant resentment eventually erupted into a full-fledged revolt in 1857, exactly a hundred years after the Battle of Plassey. British readers will know this as the Sepoy Mutiny. Within a few weeks, the bulk of the